



PHOTOS BY MELECK ELDAHSHOURY FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Olivia Eaton and her father, Matt, sat in a room at Boston Children's Hospital for her monthly IV appointment in August.

A medical mystery meets an AI sleuth

Two scientist parents used ChatGPT to help pinpoint causes of daughter's illness

By Allyson Chiu
GLOBE STAFF

Hilary Eaton was in the middle of a virtual meeting for work when her phone pinged. Glancing down, her eyes locked on the notification: A new test result had arrived in her daughter's patient portal.

For most of 5-year-old Olivia's life, the chubby-cheeked girl with blue eyes and a mischievous grin had been afflicted with confounding symptoms. As an infant, she couldn't sit up on her own. She never slept through the night. Colds lasted for weeks. When she skinned her knees while playing, the wounds wouldn't heal.

Countless doctors' visits had yielded few satisfactory answers. Olivia had been diagnosed with a connective tissue disorder. That explained her early physical challenges — her older sister, Fiona, would later be diagnosed with the same condition — but not why she was sick all the time.

Doctors said Olivia's frequent bouts of illness were likely because she was isolated from other children during the coronavirus pandemic. But Eaton couldn't shake the feeling something else was going on. Her "spidey sense," she said, was constantly tingling.

"I knew she was sick too much, too long," Eaton said.



She hoped the lab tests, ordered by an immunologist, would offer new information.

So on that January day in 2025, as chatter from the work meeting streamed from her computer, Eaton's attention was on her phone. She zoomed in on a PDF so she could read the test results.

Several numbers stood out: They measured antibodies, the body's critical line of defense against foreign invaders. Olivia had far less than a healthy child should.

Holy [expletive], Eaton thought.

Hilary Eaton prompted ChatGPT with medical concerns for her daughter Olivia at her home in Winchester.

AI, Page A14

Hung jury offers clues for retrial in Clancy case

Legal specialists say DA has to consider why 11 jurors opposed conviction

By Sean Cotter
GLOBE STAFF

When faced with high-stakes cases, some lawyers take a dry run, a mock trial to assess their arguments and evidence — essentially a dress rehearsal before pretend jurors to test the strength of their case.

The six-week murder trial of Lindsay Clancy was no mock trial. Yet the outcome — a deadlocked jury with 11 jurors apparently ready to reject the prosecution's argument the Duxbury mother is criminally responsible for the deaths of her three children — in many ways could serve the same purpose for Plymouth District Attorney Tim Cruz as he weighs whether to retry the case, lawyers said.

"As the prosecution, what I would take away is their case is on life support," said defense attorney David Yannetti, who represented Karen Read in her 2024 trial and then the retrial a year later after the first jury could not reach consensus.

In the days since the mistrial declaration, five of

JURORS, Page A16

On campuses, a split screen on climate for free speech

Differing perceptions at Northeastern, Harvard

By Mike Damiano
GLOBE STAFF

In the upheaval that followed the Gaza protests on college campuses and the Trump administration's subsequent attacks on universities, school administrators confronted a thorny challenge: How to get students and professors to speak freely when they have reason to fear the consequences?

Two Boston-area universities have produced strikingly different responses.

Harvard University undertook a multiyear experiment in remaking campus speech norms with top-down reforms, resulting in what students and professors describe as a kind of thaw on a campus where tensions over politics, ideology, and speech had thrust it into an acrimonious national debate.

Conversely, some students and professors at Northeastern University complain their adminis-

COLLEGES, Page A16

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Splash dance

Sunday: Heavy rain. High: 67-72. Low: 64-69.

Monday: Less humid, sunny. High: 73-78. Low: 53-58.

Sunrise: 6:22 Sunset: 6:58

Complete report, **A24.**

Deaths, **A18-23.**

In Vermont, new refugees touch a nerve

Afrikaners favored by Trump policy

By Paul Heintz
GLOBE STAFF

BRATTLEBORO, Vt. — When Andre Marais and his family learned last year that the Trump administration planned to welcome him and other white South Africans as refugees, he was curious but confused.

"Initially when we saw it, we were like, 'This is strange,'" he said. "Like, 'Why would someone try to protect

the white guy?'"

But like many Afrikaners — white South Africans, generally of Dutch descent — Marais was fed up with his country's crime, corruption, and, in his view, discrimination against its white minority.

"It's a lawless place," he said.

So after applying for the refugee resettlement program, Marias and 54 other Afrikaners ended up in, of all places, one of the most liberal towns in one of the most liberal states in the US.

Although it is overwhelmingly

white, Brattleboro — like much of Vermont — generally reviles the very policies that brought Marais here: President Trump's decision to end refugee programs for people of color and instead admit the descendants of those who controlled South Africa during apartheid.

That's led to a bit of awkwardness in a place that prides itself on its welcoming ways.

"It's tricky. I'll put it that way," acknowledged Joe Wiah, a Liberian refugee who now runs Brattleboro's

AFRIKANERS, Page A15

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